

[Return to Search](#)

Hausa theatre in Niger

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In Talala Mai Kaman Sake, the Troupe Amadou Dan Bassa incorporates other traditional, respected roles, those of the religious scholars, the malams, as well as the head of the samariya (Mai Samari) and the judge (Juju). (³²) In the opening scene, Mai Samari reconciles a dispute between two members of the samariya who should have a joking relationship with each other (wasan nangi). Mai Samari draws out the example of different ethnic groups within Niger having a chain of such relationships with one another:

Mai Samari: Haven't you got that in your head? If he curses you, it's not you he's cursing. If you notice, if you go from here in the east to the west, our country is all one and the same. Listen to me carefully now. In this country the Beriberi joke with the Fulani, right?

Musa: Yes.

Mai Samari: If you continue, you'll meet up with the Gwari who jokes with the man from Gobir, if you go even further, you'll meet the man from Katsina who jokes with the man from Gobir, you go even further, you'll see the man from the Arewa joking with the man from Adar ... (...) Look and you'll see all of our country has the same mother, the same father, if you go [anywhere] they'll tell you this people and that one have a joking relationship. (Scene 1) (³³)

This speech provides one of the central didactic points of the play, emphasizing traditional relationships as the basis of national unity and harmony. Audiences expect this sort of wise pronouncement from a community leader like Mai Samari. The actor chosen for the role,  216 Kailou Bako, a middle-aged man with impressive public-speaking ability, performed in accordance with those expectations, lending weight to the message of his lecture. (³⁴)

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Material Not Relevant

536

Drama

545

Musical And
Theatrical Productions

563

Ethnic Stratification

Talala Mai Kaman Sake, performance by the Troupe Amadou Dan Bassa of Zinder at the National Festival in Diffa, Niger, 8 April 1981.

Talala Mai Kaman Sake, Scene 1. The transcription is mine with help from Yazi Dogo; the English translation is mine. The original Hausa:

Mai Samari: Ba ka sa wannan a kanka? In ya zage ka ai ba kai ba ya zaga. Ai in ka lura, a ka dauka daga nan gabas zuwa yamma, [unknown]kasar wannan tamu kap! Gaba [unavailable]ayanta. Ka ji ko ka shurareni hwa! A nan [unknown]kasar nan, Baribari yana wasa da bahulatani. Ka ji ko?

Musa: To.

Mai Samari: In ka yi gaba, za ka tarda Baduwari yana wasa da Bagobiri, ka[unknown] kara yin gaba, ka tarda Bakatsine yana wasa da Bagobiri, ka [unknown]kara yin gaba, ka gan da Ba'are yana wasa da Ba'adare...

(...) Ba ka duba ka ga [unknown]kasar tamu duk uwammu daya, ubammu [unknown]daya, an ka je an ce mutum wane da wane suna wasan nangi.

Talala Mai Kaman Sake, performances in Tanout (9 March 1981), Diffa (8 April 1981), and Maradi (1 September 1981).

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